Floods and Australian ecosystems

BACKGROUND

habitat (say 'hab-i-tat') – the particular place where a group of living things live

marsupial (say 'marr-soup-ee-al') – a type of small furry mammal, with a pouch for its young

species (say 'spee-seas') – a group of living things that can breed together to produce fertile offspring

Flooding occurs in Australian ecosystems when land that is normally dry becomes covered in water. When there is heavy rain, rivers and creeks may fill up and burst their banks, covering the surrounding land in water. At some times of the year, there may be little rainfall in an area and the ground becomes very hard and dry. When heavy summer rains come, lots of water can fall very quickly. This leads to **run-off**, where water travels across the ground too quickly to be soaked into the soil. A lot of run-off can cause a fast-moving flood, called a **flash flood**.

Floods can be very damaging to some parts of ecosystems. Habitats may be destroyed and animals may drown, upsetting the delicate balance of the ecosystem. But some species benefit from flooding. River red gums need flooding for their seeds to germinate (sprout), and populations of frogs, fish and wetland birds can grow in number after floods.

☞ **1** Complete the table to show singular and plural forms of these flood words. Write the definition of each word, in your own words.

Singular word	Plural word	Definition
	floods	
rainfall	rainfall	
	creeks	
	shrubs	

2 List two negative effects that flooding has on species in ecosystems.

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3 List two positive effects that flooding has on species in ecosystems.

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ISBN 978 1 92571 064 9
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